

VI. Regarding the Ruling Class

At the very end of 2022, I finally realized a consequence I had never considered before; my worldview was reshaped within a few short days. What exactly this discovery implies, even today I cannot provide a definitive answer.

It is undoubtedly a tragedy first and foremost, yet it is also an undeniable victory—a victory belonging to the scientific spirit and human free thought.

This discovery might harbor the opportunity for change. It may seem too early to say so now, but I suppose even in the first century of the birth of modern science, the vast majority of humanity's most crucial inventions derived from experience rather than the guidance of scientific theory. But no enterprise is accomplished overnight. People must always first learn to understand the world, and only upon the foundation of understanding does the possibility of progressive transformation through subjective initiative (主观能动性) arise. I believe that regardless, it should be recorded first, for it will inevitably aid those who read it later.

1. Letting the Ruling Class Rule was the Optimal Solution in Historical Periods

A question had troubled me for a very long time. When I compared the political reforms that occurred in Japan and China over the last millennium, I found that although the Chinese court also attempted to reduce expenses through means like cutting the number of officials, its primary method was always to "broaden the sources of income" (开源)—that is, exhausting all means to increase tax revenues.

Conversely, while Japanese Shoguns and *Daimyos* also attempted to increase income through means like stimulating industries, what they emphasized most was always to "cut expenditures" (节流)—that is, demanding that the *Samurai* reduce unnecessary consumption and practice frugality.

Now, this question, along with other striking differences between China and Japan—such as Japan's free and prosperous **early modern** (近世) civil culture, the ability of Japanese peasants to negotiate directly with the ruling class and sign contracts, and the astonishing discrepancies in the form, intensity, and objectives of Sino-Japanese peasant uprisings—are all answered by the same fundamental fact.

Namely: **In Japan, the ruling class *actually* exercised rule; whereas in China, the ruling class failed to do so, and the entity exercising political power was a detached bureaucratic stratum (脱产的官僚阶层) (or "class"—in fact, the degree of confusion with which Chinese people use these terms surpasses an outsider's imagination).**

The disastrous articulation of the term "ruling class" initially stemmed from the imprudence of Marx and Engels, but I sense that in China, the concept of this term has been deliberately obfuscated.

Simply put, in the context of contemporary Chinese, the term "ruling class" possesses two meanings. First, it refers to the class that holds a dominant position in economic production—that is, this class controls the primary means of production (or factors of production). Second, it refers to the class that grasps state power and rules politically.

The greatest misstep of Marx and Engels lay in the fact that they themselves grew up in Europe. When they observed their surroundings during the prime of their lives, what they saw was not just any random corner of the globe, but a Europe that had successfully traversed the **feudalization** (封建化) stage, successfully traversed the **early modern** absolute state stage, and had already reached the capitalist era.

The "world" they were familiar with was a far cry from the world as a whole, because it was the most successful region among all parts of the world. In terms of the completeness of social development, it is certainly representative; but if one wishes to observe the successes and failures in the history of human societies, it possesses no representativeness whatsoever. It is just like how you cannot judge the level of an entire class solely by looking at the few students with the best grades.

If we count from the early city-states of the Aegean Sea, excluding the Eastern European regions ruled by Russia, the rest of Europe completely experienced every conventional evolutionary stage of human history, and nowhere did any anomalies (异变) occur. This means that Europe's ruling class always experienced a complete life cycle: rising, developing during transition periods, exercising independent class rule, declining during transition periods, and exiting the historical stage.

Marx and Engels lived in an era where capitalism was booming and their home of Europe possessed an absolute advantage over the whole world. In their lifetimes and from their perspective, the bourgeoisie was going through the stage of ambitiously executing its class rule. Moreover, looking back at European history, they did not observe any "anomalies."

Therefore, they made a presumptive judgment on a fatal question: **that the class holding the dominant position economically inevitably attains power politically, and consequently, the ideology of this class becomes the dominant ideology.**

However, this assumption is fundamentally wrong. From here on, when I use the term "ruling class," I am referring solely to the class that dominates economic production, without necessarily affirming that it has already acquired state power.

The histories of China and Japan demonstrate that the political power of the ruling class is fundamentally not obtained naturally. In certain cases, this ruling power must be seized through struggle (as in Japan), and there are cases where the seizure of power fails (as in China).

In reality, Marx and Engels completely ignored this crucial class struggle—namely, **the struggle of the ruling class to seize power**. Almost all varieties of self-proclaimed Marxists have, intentionally or unintentionally, neglected this point, virtually equating class struggle exclusively with the movement of the ruled class rebelling against the ruling class. Exactly how this neglect originally formed could probably only be understood by peering into the minds of Marx and Engels themselves back then; today, we can only offer some deductions.

Looking at the target of the ruling class's struggle, it is naturally not the ruled class, but rather a non-productive, *rentier* stratum (食利阶层) that possesses the power to comprehensively distribute social resources. It does not necessarily manifest in a highly homogenous form; for example, in China, it manifested as highly pure hierarchical bureaucrats (科层官僚), while in Byzantium, alongside bureaucrats, a portion manifested as the Orthodox Church.

But regardless, this target obstructing the ruling class from seizing power inherently possesses the power to manipulate state apparatuses. Therefore, practically viewing it as the "government" itself is not unwarranted.

Such a monstrosity (怪胎) cannot be generated under just any conditions. Tracing its origins, it dates back to periods of class transition where the expansion of government power failed to recede normally. The example of China has made this abundantly clear, and the same holds true for Byzantium, situated between Europe and Asia. This regime never experienced complete **feudalization** and instead increasingly exhibited the characteristics of Oriental Despotism (东方君主制).

Russia provides a very recent example (*I might discuss this country again in the future*). In the process of transitioning from the **feudal system** to a capitalist society, we first note that Russia's **feudal system** developed incompletely; the personal power of the Tsar overwhelmed the feudal contracts among lords, which subsequently meant Russia's bourgeoisie also developed incompletely. The consequence of doing so was that Russia's **early modern** period became incredibly protracted, and the absolute regime did not completely collapse until World War I.

However, the Soviet Bolshevik regime established thereafter was even more cunning. Lenin and his cohorts exploited the oversight of Marx and Engels to provide justification for an even more totalitarian and terroristic bureaucratic rule. Furthermore, alongside their so-called "export of revolution" policies, they scattered these disastrous consequences across the globe, and to this day, their pernicious legacy remains unpurged.

From the above perspectives, I believe the earliest oversight by Marx and Engels was largely due to one point: **they far too deeply underestimated the power and consciousness of the government itself.**

An organization numbering in the tens of thousands, aggregating the social elites, capable of partially controlling and guiding social wealth, and manipulating the apparatuses of violence, could *never* possibly play the role of an obedient robot.

Historically speaking, the ruling class *must* tame such a machine to serve itself. If it cannot defeat and conquer it, then it can only become a slave under the whip of the state apparatus—let alone transforming its own ideology into the mainstream ideology of society.

For instance, in China, we can find "thousands" of examples demonstrating that the will of the **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) was never translated into the will of the state. One particularly critical issue is the so-called inheritance system.

If we observe the typical **feudal societies** that once existed in Europe or Japan, it is not difficult to discover that as the feudal system matured, estate inheritance increasingly leaned toward concentration in the hands of specific offspring (primarily the eldest son), rather than the widespread **partible inheritance** (析产) seen during the early stages of **feudalization**.

Simple logical deduction helps us understand the inevitability of this evolution. For societies in early **feudalization**, production in small social units is the most efficient; thus, partible inheritance among children is advantageous for expanding the family's total **productive forces**.

As **productive forces** further develop to such a degree that even production in small social units generates considerable surplus, not only does society's demand for material exchange rise, but

people—especially the ruling class—will realize that concentrating this surplus for investment (utilization) (*which refers not just to economic investment, but more likely political investment*) is vastly more beneficial for the development of the entire family. Any observer looking at the entire developmental trajectory of the Middle Ages in Europe and Japan would find it exceedingly difficult to ignore this obvious shift in inheritance systems.

However, in China, due to the failure of *feudalization*, the bureaucratic system flagrantly carried out its restoration beginning with the Sui and Tang empires. A fact easily observable to people is that, starting from the Tang Dynasty, the laws of successive dynasties comprehensively supported the system of equal property division.

If we stand from the viewpoint of the bureaucrats—especially the emperor himself—then this legal policy indeed thwarted the capacity of the *feudal landlords* (封建领主) to interfere in politics.

Contrary to the CCP's propaganda that evil landlords exploiting the common people were omnipresent throughout China, the degree of land concentration in China during the Ming and Qing dynasties was considerably weak. In some places, such as the Guanzhong region in Shaanxi where I currently live, claiming that landlords played any leading role in the local economy is sheer flattery.

Therefore, we can say with absolute certainty: **although from the Sui and Tang down to the Qing Dynasty, China's *theoretical* ruling class was the landlord class, in the face of overwhelming bureaucratic rule, it was utterly impossible for them to extend their will to the entire society.**

The greatest tragedy of Marx and Engels lay in the fact that they could not possibly have seen another possibility existing thousands of miles away. The Germany where they lived their youth was a region where state power had long been exceedingly weak. Ever since the High Middle Ages, the authority of the Holy Roman Emperor had plummeted, and hundreds of princes had acted autonomously for centuries.

Growing up in such an environment and historical memory, Marx and Engels inevitably developed a mindset along the lines of "*what does the government even amount to?*"

After all, the flow of information in the 19th century was not as convenient as today, so expecting two sociologists back then to earnestly understand the historical developmental paths of different regions worldwide was indeed difficult. Thus, Marx and Engels, based on the prejudices of their own lived experiences, arrived at a disastrous conclusion.

Over the past century or more, and throughout my life from childhood to the present, people have been enthusiastic about discussing the disastrous consequences caused by the ruling class exploiting the ruled class. Yet, almost no one discusses what happens if the ruling class is *unable* even to exercise class rule.

Now, judging from this brilliant comparison between China and Japan, an atypical class society can only result in far more severe catastrophes.

Returning to the issue of political reforms in the histories of these two countries makes this abundantly clear. In Japan, the ruling class was genuinely ruling the state, and they themselves were directing economic production. Therefore, any attempt to extort more exorbitant taxes and miscellaneous levies (苛捐杂税) from society was, essentially, slicing flesh off their own bodies to eat. Consequently, although Japanese rulers also encouraged the development of specialized industries, their primary method during reforms could never be to enhance their capacity to extract

social wealth; they would only highly emphasize reducing unnecessary consumption—that is, cutting expenditures (节流).

However, in China, the political structure was vastly different. The bureaucrats ruling here constituted a **detached stratum** (脱产的阶层); they themselves did not engage in social production. Therefore, when political crises intensified, the first reaction of the Chinese bureaucrats and emperor was always to expand the scope and intensity of taxation as much as possible, because no matter what, this was not slicing flesh directly off the rulers.

For the rulers of the Chinese **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家), both the peasants (as the ruled class) and the landlords (as the ruling class) were subjects to be ruled over. Given the opportunity, the bureaucracy would absolutely never let slip the chance to exploit them. Under such circumstances, expecting the imperial family and the bureaucratic class to prioritize frugality is simply the pipe dream of a madman (痴人说梦).

Obviously, the differences between these two systems do not merely appear in short-term policy choices; over the long span of history, they can only become ever more pronounced.

First, only when the class that economically dominates production grasps political power do they actually possess the strength and willingness to undertake the work of improving production. This is because they possess both the administrative means to execute improvements and the capability to ensure that the profits generated by production advancements belong to themselves, rather than inexplicably falling into the hands of the government.

Therefore, when the ruling class indeed possesses the ruling power, production surpluses are overwhelmingly channeled into investments for expanded reproduction, as well as into supporting science, culture, and the arts—which have longer return cycles (*the so-called technological investment*). This very investment and demand is the fundamental guarantee for the emergence of modern science and technology.

In a **bureaucratic state**, however, any production surplus is completely exhausted, layer by layer, entirely within the bureaucratic system itself. The amount available for expanding production is infinitesimally small. In fact, judging from our country's history, in the late stages of every dynasty, when the bureaucratic system became hyper-inflated and dysfunctional, let alone expanding production, it became impossible to even maintain the current scale of production. What inevitably followed was the **total collapse of the entire society** (全社会的总崩溃) and the deaths of tens of millions of people.

It must be pointed out that the "total collapse of society" mentioned here does not mean the social production in every single region within China's borders disintegrated simultaneously. Rather, certain vital regions of China collapsed first, and the ensuing famines, plagues, mass refugee flights, and peasant wars triggered a domino effect. These regions that collapsed first were often the most profoundly suffering lands in China—primarily the Great Plains north of the Yangtze River and the Yellow River flooded areas (黄泛区)—where the destructive power of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚体制) reached its absolute zenith. Under specific conditions, the occurrence of natural disasters could also cause a certain region to collapse first, because weakened by the **restoration-bureaucratic system**, ancient Chinese society severely lacked resilience against natural calamities.

Second, history demonstrates that when the ruling class directly grasps political power, it has a far greater need to interact directly with the ruled class. This is especially true in the **feudal era**, a highly specific class society.

As mentioned earlier, the ruling class possessing land in a **feudal society** resided much more dispersed across vast rural areas compared to the class societies that preceded and succeeded it. This led to a phenomenon they had no choice but to face: for **feudal lords**, especially grassroots feudal lords, the time they had to invest in dealing with the ruled peasants was even vastly greater than the time spent dealing with other feudal lords.

Looking back at the origins of human history from the vantage point of modern society today, there is no doubt that it was precisely the interactions between rulers and the ruled during the feudal era that forged many of the cornerstones of modern society—including contracts, civil rights awareness, and the concept of the sacred inviolability of private property.

When I read the history of Japan's Muromachi period, what shocked me the most was the degree of importance the Japanese back then attached to contractual documents. Later, when I read about the land surveys (*Kenchi* / 检地) conducted by the Oda-Toyotomi (*Shokuhō*) regime during the Azuchi-Momoyama period—the transition from the *Chūsei* (Middle Ages) to the **early modern** era—I was stunned beyond words to learn that the magistrates (*Bugyō* / 奉行) dispatched by the government would have the land survey results of each village confirmed by the villagers themselves, and a copy would be retained within the village!

The government and the common people signed contracts in such explicitly clear ways, and both sides acknowledged their validity. From the Middle Ages onward, when Japanese commoners believed taxes were unreasonable, they would righteously bring out their contractual documents to protest. **This is something utterly and entirely unimaginable in China.**

As for urban autonomy and feudal contracts, the various countries of Western Europe clearly went much further, which is arguably a crucial factor as to why modern civilization was born there.

Third, the **bureaucratic state** severely suppressed people's thoughts, especially for the ruling class, who otherwise possessed the surplus capacity for scientific research.

This suppression initially manifested in draconian censorship. When reading the history of the Edo period, I often find it difficult to comprehend Japanese scholars' definition of "literary inquisitions" (文字獄). Because a writer published a work the Shogunate did not wish to see published, he was penalized with 50 days of wearing handcuffs—yet the Japanese actually deemed this an *"unforgivable crime of a despotic government severely violating human rights."*

To be completely honest, such a perspective is simply too "progressive" for the vast majority of Chinese residents; one must realize that even today, illegal detention has yet to vanish in our country. During the contemporaneous Ming and Qing dynasties, if one was implicated in a literary inquisition, managing to spare one's entire clan from execution was already considered fortunate (*in popular terms, female family members were generally exiled or forced into the Jiaofangsi / state brothels*). Merely facing 50 days of detention would be utterly unimaginable.

European political persecution appears equally laughable to the Chinese. Not even mentioning the Renaissance and subsequent periods, take the High Middle Ages: even if distinct heretical thoughts (异端思想) and suspected witches appeared in a locality, the Catholic Church would surprisingly

organize a court to conduct a trial! This is simply inconceivable. In our country, if the emperor intends to kill one of his subjects, he need only fabricate any pretext at will. Why, then, would he undergo rigorous legal procedures for a trial? In Chinese History, the judiciary is nothing more than a performance.

However, direct ideological control is not even the most crucial aspect. In China, Shang Yang (商鞅)—a thinker renowned for his expertise in taming humanity—heavily emphasized that **rather than controlling people's thoughts, it is far better to render them fundamentally incapable of thinking at all**. (Although it is widely recognized within China that *The Book of Lord Shang* (*Shangjun Shu*) was not entirely the creation of Shang Yang himself—undoubtedly featuring "contributions" from his disciples and like-minded successors—Chinese people generally attribute the ideology within the text collectively to him for the sake of clarity. Shang Yang himself has come to exist almost as a *cultural symbol*.)

In fact, Chinese rulers are exceptionally adept at this. In our country, the ultimate goal of so-called "management" is to inflict endless trouble upon the managed, forcing them to continuously make "mistakes" and thereby fabricating excuses to punish them. In such an environment, whether it is the peasants as the ruled class or the landlords as the ruling class, it is exceedingly difficult for anyone to engage in complex thinking beyond mere survival. The former only wishes to ensure they do not starve to death tomorrow, while the latter is forced to constantly maneuver and flatter within the bureaucratic system just to maintain their existing status.

Bluntly speaking, from the Sui and Tang dynasties all the way until the late Qing was forced to open its doors, I have genuinely never heard of or learned about any Chinese thinker worth mentioning. In reality, regarding the Chinese intellectuals of the Tang, Song, Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, not a single one clearly knew what historical stage they were currently in, let alone possessed any judgment regarding the direction of the future.

It was not until the late Ming and early Qing, during an event as profoundly shocking to the Han people as the Manchus **Entering the Pass (Ru Guan / 入关)**, that a select few individuals seemingly caught a glimpse of certain clues—only to retreat back into the fortress of Cheng-Zhu Neo-Confucianism (程朱理学) within a short span of two generations.

In a **bureaucratic state**, people find it difficult to conduct scientific research, and pragmatically have absolutely no motivation to pursue such enterprises. Here, no scientific creation can be translated into protected wealth and honor; stripping away these rewards is effortlessly easy for the court, and costs the latter absolutely nothing.

Is this situation not exactly the same today? People value official ranks while disregarding academic degrees. Essentially, this is because official ranks play a decisive role in the allocation of social resources. This is precisely the goal Shang Yang wished to achieve back then: "*All benefits issue from a single hole*" (利出一孔)—making academic pursuits utterly worthless by comparison.

Coupled with the fact that the **bureaucratic state** was equipped with the imperial examination system (科举制度)—a potent weapon—it could achieve indirect control over society's value orientations and ideologies without resorting to armed force, ensuring that all inventions and discoveries capable of instigating change would end in miscarriage.

If we summarize the three points above, we will find that they are listed precisely in the sequence of Marx and Engels' fundamental standpoint: that matter determines consciousness, and **social being** (社会存在) determines **social consciousness** (社会意识).

The **first point** indicates that compared to a class society, people in a bureaucratic society lack both the surplus capacity and the willingness (既无余力也无意愿) to expand production, improve technology, and invest in the fields of science, culture, and the arts. Therefore, from the perspective of the development of **productive forces** (生产力), a bureaucratic society is inevitably subjected to colossal restrictions.

The **second point** indicates that compared to a class society, the Chinese bureaucratic society did not experience the effective restructuring of social relations seen since the Middle Ages, fundamentally lacking the essential elements to enter modern society. This means its **relations of production** (生产关系) are extremely backward and deformed.

The **third point** indicates that compared to a class society, China's bureaucratic society is far more imprisoned and reactionary in thought. Let alone any progress in people's worldviews, philosophies of life, values, or the scientific and cultural knowledge they possess, numerous pieces of evidence actually prove that over the last millennium, the cognitive level of our country's populace has been regressing (*relevant content will be supplemented later*). This means that from the perspective of **social consciousness**, this is no longer a question of progress or backwardness; I believe the term "**degeneration**" (退化) is perhaps far more fitting.

Such layered, compounding shackles utterly strangled the possibility of our country entering modern civilization. Bluntly speaking, just looking at the disastrous ecological deterioration during the late Qing Dynasty, if the "strong ships and powerful cannons" (坚船利炮) of the foreigners had not blown open China's gates, it is hard to say that this place would not have turned into a supersized Easter Island, or at least a supersized Mesopotamian Plain (*where the core civilization could not ensure its own political security and was perpetually and repeatedly conquered by peripheral ethnic groups*).

In fact, judging from the frequent *Ru Guan* (Entering the Pass / 入关) by peripheral ethnic minorities during the latter half of China's imperial era, becoming a supersized Mesopotamia can no longer be called a mere possibility, but a harsh reality.

Only by earnestly understanding China's historical trajectory will people emphasize a fact that *must* be emphasized: in a class society, cruel oppression by the ruling class over the ruled class indeed exists. However, in the past, when **productive forces** (生产力) could not possibly support a classless communist society, "**letting the ruling class rule**" **was indeed history's optimal solution**.

This, of course, does not mean that the struggles of the ruled class rebelling against the ruling class were meaningless. The histories of both Europe and Japan demonstrate that uprisings by the lower classes genuinely propelled social progress and forced the ruling class to reform its rule. The proper historical trajectory of humanity was thus jointly created by both the ruling and ruled classes.

Even if one finds these theoretical analyses difficult to discern, they need only look at the history that actually occurred in our country to effortlessly conclude: for the ruled class—which constitutes the vast majority of the population—dealing with the ruling class is vastly superior to falling,

alongside the ruling class, into the massive cage of the bureaucratic system within a bureaucratic society.

Anyone who understands Chinese history cannot possibly avoid being shocked by our country's violently fluctuating historical population curves. During dynastic transitions, one-third to two-thirds of the entire country's population would be collectively wiped out. From the millions dead in the late Han Dynasty to the potentially hundred million dead during the Taiping Rebellion (and the synchronous surrounding wars), the scale of a *single* population annihilation would be enough to wipe out an entire European country, with deaths to spare.

A deeply traumatic historical event like the Black Death occurred merely once for Westerners, but for the Chinese, it was inevitably seen once every ten generations. Events of staggering abnormal mortality caused by wars, famines, and plagues did not cease until the latter half of the last century.

While the element of natural disasters cannot be ruled out, how could such dense and cruel catastrophes occurring exclusively in China *not* be the disastrous consequence of the collapse of social functions (*functions that include not just maintaining order, but also correcting and curbing tyranny*)?

There are still many photographs and historical documents proving the existential state of the Chinese commoners during the late Qing. We do not even need to compare them to Europe, which dominated the world at the time; merely contrasting them with our neighbor, Japan, is sufficient. The verdict on who succeeded and who failed is absolutely self-evident.

As for Marx and Engels specifically, the mistakes they made back then were no big deal. After all, when a person stands at the frontier of a field with no predecessors to follow, making mistakes is exceptionally normal. If Marx and Engels definitely made any mistake, it was perhaps being overly confident and overestimating the developmental level of social sciences and philosophy at the time, believing they could guide the operation of the world or even navigate natural sciences—a notion stringently trained scientists naturally disbelieve.

Standing at the dawn of the third decade of the 21st century, I believe the path adopted by the so-called social democratic parties of Europe is relatively rational. Regardless of the actual validity of the theories of their "mentors," Marx and Engels, these socialist parties—who supposedly "*capitulated to the bourgeoisie*"—will, sooner or later, sort the true from the false through realistic practice.

The entities that truly warped this mistake into a regime of extreme atrocity were the Russian Bolshevik Party led by Lenin.

These conspirators (野心家) fully exploited the fatal oversight of Marx and Engels—who ignored the fact that the government, as an independent stratum, could wield colossal power, and mischaracterized the primary contradiction of social being as solely the antagonism between the ruling and ruled classes—using Marxism to endorse their own totalitarian bureaucratic rule.

Lenin's "creativity" lay in the fact that he theoretically embellished the general bureaucratic politics generated during the process of class transition, which the Soviet Union and the subsequent regimes established under its influence termed the "**Vanguard**" (先锋队).

Consequently, within the context of the so-called communist states since the Soviet Union, the bureaucratic regimes they established were no longer viewed as the natural outcome of social

development, but rather as combat machines that absolutely *had* to be established to overthrow the old society.

In reality, however, they were neither willing nor able to destroy an old society. All these varied forms of propaganda ultimately served only to provide legitimacy for bureaucratic rule. The Communist Party of the Soviet Union concealed the staggering privileges held within the Party, and framed all the catastrophes caused by bureaucratic rule as "necessary sacrifices" on the path to a new society.

Most importantly, by the 20th century, the science and technology possessed by humanity were incomparable to previous eras. This enabled the rulers of Soviet-style states to blatantly erect imaginary enemies—first the landlords, later the capitalists—without needing to at least superficially acknowledge the scholar-elites (士绅) as the pillars of the state, as the Ming and Qing bureaucratic empires did. This was because, following the Industrial Revolution, the power possessed by the government had become vastly stronger than ever before.

Up to the present, this is blatantly the most malicious and maximally destructive political system, accompanied by the most dangerous political propaganda, to have ever appeared in human history. It bears absolutely no comparison to the Nazis' short-lived twelve-year "Thousand-Year Reich." In the long run, the destruction wrought by Hitler absolutely cannot be mentioned in the same breath as that caused by the Soviet Union.

1, 让统治阶级进行统治, 在历史时期是最优解

在很早以前开始有一个问题就一直困扰着我, 当我对比日本和中国最近一千年发生的政治改革, 就会发现虽然中国朝廷也试图通过削减官吏数量这样的手段减少开支, 但是首要的办法永远是“开源”, 也就是想尽办法增加税入; 而日本的将军和大名虽然也试图通过振兴产业这样的手段增加收入, 但是他们最强调的永远是“节流”, 也就是要求武士们减少不必要的消费进行节俭。现在这个问题和中国与日本之间其他显著的不同点, 例如日本近世自由繁荣的市民文化, 日本农民能够直接与统治阶级交涉并签订契约, 中日农民起义的形式烈度和目的上惊人的差异, 一起被同一个基本的事实所回答。那就是, 在日本统治阶级实际进行的统治, 而在中国统治阶级没有做到这一点, 行使政治权力的是一个脱产的官僚阶层(或者“阶级”, 实际上中国人用这些词语的混乱程度超乎外人的想象)。

“统治阶级”这个术语的灾难性表达最初来源于马克思和恩格斯的不审慎, 但是我感觉到在中国, 这个词的概念一定是有意被混淆的。简单来说, 在当代汉语的语境下, “统治阶级”这个词具有两种含义, 第一是指在经济生产上占有主导地位的阶级, 即这一阶级控制了主要的生产资料(或生产要素); 第二是掌握国家政权在政治上进行统治的阶级。马克思和恩格斯最大的失误在于, 他们本人生长在欧洲, 当他们在年富力强的岁月里观察周围, 看到的不是地球的任意一个角落, 而是顺利越过封建化阶段, 顺利越过近世绝对主义国家阶段, 已经到达资本主义时代的欧洲。他们熟悉的“世界”跟整个世界相去甚远, 因为这是世界各个部分中最为成功的地区, 从社会发展的完整性上来讲当然有代表性, 但是如果想看人类社会历史中的成败, 那就没有任何代表性了, 就如同你不能只通过看班里成绩最好的几个学生来判断整个班的水平。如果从爱琴海的早期城邦算起, 除掉俄罗斯统治的东欧地区, 余下的欧洲完整地经历了人类历史每一个常规演变阶段, 并且没有哪里发生过异变。这意味着欧洲的统治阶级总是经历了兴起, 在过渡时期发展, 独立进行阶级统治, 在过渡时期衰退, 退出历史舞台这一完整的生命历程。而马克思和恩格斯就生活在资本主义蓬勃发展, 自己生活的欧洲对全世界拥有绝对优势的年代, 在他们的生命以他们的视角看来, 资产阶级正在经历野心勃勃地贯彻其阶级统治的阶段, 而他们回顾欧洲的历史有没有观察到什么“异数”, 因此他们在一个致命的问题上做出了想当然的判断, 那就是在经济上取得主导地位的阶级必然在政治上取得权力, 进而这个阶级的思想就是占统治地位的思想。然而, 这个假设根本就是错的。接下来, 当我说到“统治阶级”这个词的时候, 指的只是在经济生产上占主导的阶级, 并不一定确认其已经取得国家权力。

中国和日本的历史表明，统治阶级的政治权力根本不是自然就可以获得的，在某些情况下，这种统治权必须通过斗争来夺取（日本），并且存在夺权失败的情况（中国）。实际上，马克思和恩格斯完全忽略了这种至关重要的阶级斗争，也就是统治阶级夺权的斗争，几乎所有的形形色色的自称马克思主义者都有意无意地忽视这一点，几乎把阶级斗争等价于被统治阶级反抗统治阶级的运动。这种忽视最初是怎么形成的恐怕只有钻进当年马克思和恩格斯本人的头脑才能一清二楚，现在我们只能进行一些推测。

从统治阶级斗争的对象来看自然不是被统治阶级，而表现为一个不事生产的，但是却有权力对社会资源进行总体分配的食利阶层，它不一定具有非常同质的表现，例如在中国表现为非常纯粹的科层官僚，然而在拜占庭除了官僚以外会有部分表现为东正教会。但无论如何，这个阻止统治阶级夺取权力的对象本身就拥有操控国家对象的力量，因而实际上把它视为政府本身也未尝不可。这样一种怪胎不是在任何条件下都能产生，从源头上看可以追溯到阶级交替时期政府权力膨胀未能正常消退，中国的例子已经说得很清楚，立于欧亚之间的拜占庭同样如此，这个政权从来没有经历过完整的封建化反倒越来越表现得具有东方君主制的色彩。俄罗斯是一个非常晚近的例子（关于这个国家日后或许会再提），再由封建制度向资本主义社会过渡的过程中，我们首先注意到俄国的封建制度发展的就不完全，沙皇个人的权力压倒了领主之间的封建契约，进而俄国的资产阶级发展也不完全。这样做的后果是俄国的近代变得极为漫长，绝对主义政权直到第一次世界大战才彻底崩溃，然而随之建立起的苏联布尔什维克政权则更为狡猾，列宁及其同党利用马克思和恩格斯的疏忽为更为极权和恐怖主义的官僚统治提供依据，并且随着所谓输出革命的政策将恶果洒向全球，直到今天其遗毒仍然没有清除。

从以上角度而言，我认为马克思和恩格斯最早的疏忽很大程度上是因为一点，那就是他们太过轻视政府自身的权力和意识，一个人数过万，汇集了社会精英能够部分掌控并引导社会财富并且操纵暴力机关的组织，就绝对不可能扮演一个顺从的机器人角色。从历史上看，统治阶级必须要驯服这样一个机器，为自己服务，一旦不能战而胜之那么也只能做国家机器皮鞭下的奴隶，更不要提什么把自己的思想转化为社会的主流思想了。比如在中国我们能找到“成千上万”的例子说明封建地主阶级的意志没有转化为国家意志，一个特别重要的问题就是所谓遗产继承制问题，如果我们观察欧洲或者日本曾经典型的封建社会，那么就不难发现随着封建体制的成熟遗产继承越来越倾向于集中在个别子女（主要是长子）手中，而不再像封建化早期那样普遍的析产。简单的逻辑推断使我们明白这种演变有其必然性，对于封建化早期的社会而言，以小社会单位进行生产是最具有效率的，因此进行在子女之间进行析产对于扩大家族总的生产力是有利的。随着生产力的进一步发展到了这样一种程度，即使以小的社会单位进行的生产也产生了可观的盈余，那么不但社会对于物质交换的需求上升了，而且人们特别是统治阶级会意识到，将这样的剩余集中起来进行投资（使用），这不只是指经济上的投资更可能是政治上的投资，对于整个家族的发展更为有利。任何观察者在观察欧洲和日本整个中世纪的发展历程，都很难忽视遗产继承制的这种明显变化。

但是在中国由于封建化的失败，从隋唐帝国开始官僚制堂而皇之地进行复辟，人们很容易看到的一个事实是，从唐代开始历代的法律都在整体上支持财产均分制，如果我们站在官僚特别是皇帝本人的观点上看，那么这一法律政策确实阻止了封建土地主对政治的干涉能力。与中共所宣传的中国全国各地到处都是剥削百姓的邪恶地主不同，明清两代中国的土地集中程度相当微弱，在一些地方，比如我现在所生活的陕西关中地区，说地主在当地经济中扮演什么主导角色都是抬举了。因此我们可以很肯定地说，尽管从隋唐到清朝中国理论上的统治阶级是地主阶级，但是在压倒性的官僚统治面前根本就不可能把自己的意志推广到全社会。马克思和恩格斯最大的悲剧在于他们不可能看到万里之外的另一种可能，他们年轻时所生活的德国是一个国家权力长期以来非常微弱的地区，自中世纪盛期以来神圣罗马帝国皇帝的权威就一落千丈，上百个诸侯各行其是已经有数个世纪之久。马克思和恩格斯在这种环境和历史记忆中成长，就不可避免地产生一种“政府算个什么东西”这样的思想。19世纪的信息流通毕竟不能像今天一样方便，因此指望两位社会学家在当年去认真了解全世界不同地区的历史发展路径也是有困难的，因此马克思和恩格斯就是这样基于自己生活的偏见得到了灾难性的结论。

在过去一个多世纪里，以及在我从幼年至今的生活中，人们热衷于谈论统治阶级剥削被统治阶级会造成什么样的恶果，却几乎无人谈论统治阶级如果连进行阶级统治都做不到会怎么样。现在从中国和日本这组绝妙的对比来看，非典型的阶级社会只能造成更严重的灾难。回到这两个国家历史上政治改革的问题就再明白不过了，在日本，统治阶级真的在统治国家，他们自己就在主导着经济生产，因而任何变着法地从社会搜刮更多的苛捐杂税，本质上都是从自己身上割肉吃。因而日本的统治者虽然也鼓励特色

产业的发展，但是在改革中必然不可能以增强对社会财富的汲取能力为主要手段，只会高度强调消减不必要的消费也即节流。然而在中国政治结构迥然不同，统治这里的官僚本身是一个脱产的阶层，他们自身并不进行社会生产，因此当政治危机加剧时，中国的官僚和皇帝的第一反应永远是尽可能扩大税收的范围和力度，因为无论如何这不是直接从统治者身上割肉。对于中国官僚国家的统治者来说，无论是作为被统治阶级的农民，还是作为统治阶级的地主都是被其统治的对象，只要有会，就绝对不会放过剥削他们，在这种情况下指望皇室及官僚阶级把节俭放到首位，简直就是痴人说梦了。

而这两种体制的差异显然不仅出现在短期内的政策选择上，从历史长期来看只能变得更为显著。

第一，当在经济上主导生产的阶级掌握政治权力的时候，他们实际上才能具有力量和意愿进行改进生产这一工作，因为他们既拥有行政手段去进行改良，又能确保生产进步所带来的收益为自己所有，而不是莫名其妙地就归了政府。因此当统治阶级的确拥有统治权的时候，生产盈余被更多地用于投资扩大再生产，以及回报周期更长的对科学文化艺术的支持（所谓技术投资），这种投入和需求本身就是现代科学技术产生的基本保障。而在官僚国家，任何生产盈余都会在整个官僚体制内部被一层一层完全耗尽，能用于扩大生产的寥寥无几，实际上按照我国的历史来看，在每一个王朝后期官僚体制极度膨胀和失效的情况下，不要说扩大生产，连维持当前生产规模都已经做不到了，随之而来的就是整个社会的总崩溃和千万级别人口的死亡。必须指出，这里所说的社会总崩溃并非整个中国境内所有地区的社会生产全部瓦解，而是中国的一些重要地区先崩溃了，随之而来的饥荒、瘟疫、逃难和农民战争引起了多米诺骨牌效应。这些先崩溃的地区往往是中国最为苦难深重的土地，主要为长江以北的大平原和黄泛区，复辟官僚体制的破坏力在这里达到了极点。特定条件下自然灾害的出现也会导致某个地区率先崩溃，因为在复辟官僚体制的削弱下古代中国社会对于天灾极度缺少抵抗能力。

第二，当统治阶级直接掌握政权的时候，历史表明其更有需求与被统治阶级进行直接互动，这在封建时代这一特殊的阶级社会尤为如此。如前所述，在封建社会拥有土地的统治阶级居住比起之前和之后的两种阶级社会都更为分散在广大的农村地区，这就导致了一个他们不得不面对的现象，对于封建领主特别是基层的封建主来说，与被统治的农民打交道所必须付出的时间甚至要远大于与其他封建领主打交道。站在现代社会这个时间节点往人类历史的来处回看，毫无疑问，正是封建时代统治者与被统治者的互动塑造了现代社会的许多基石，包括契约，人权意识和私有财产神圣不可侵犯的观念。当我阅读日本室町时代的历史时，最令我感到震惊的就是当年日本人对于契约文书的重视程度，等我读到由中世向近世转变的安土桃山时期织丰政权所进行的检地时，对于政府派出的奉行将每个村庄的检地结果由该村人员确认之后保留在村内这一点更是惊讶到无可复加。政府与百姓以如此清晰的方式签订契约，并且双方都认可其效应，从中世开始，当日本百姓认为税收不合理的时候，就会理直气壮地拿出契约文书进行抗议，这在中国是完完全全不可想象的事情。而在城市自治和封建契约方面，西欧各个国家显然走得更远，这也是为什么现代文明会诞生于此的一个重要因素吧。

第三，官僚国家严重地压制了人们的思想，特别是对具有余力进行科学研究的统治阶级而言。这种压制首先表现在严苛的言论管控上，我在看江户时期的历史时经常对于日本学者关于“文字狱”的定义感到难以理解，因为出版了幕府所不希望出版的作品，作家被处以戴手铐刑 50 天，而日本人居然认为这是“专制政府严重侵犯人权的不可饶恕的罪行”。说实话，这种观点对于大部分中国居民来说实在是过于进步了，要知道直到今天我国的非法拘留尚且没有消失。而同时期的明清两朝，如果是触犯文字狱能不死全家（这是通俗的说法，女性成员一般是处于流放或者充入教坊司）都不错了，居然仅仅刑拘 50 天，这是完全不可想象的事情。欧洲的政治迫害在中国人看来也是十分可笑的，即使不说文艺复兴及之后的时期，就拿中世纪盛期来说，即使一个地方出现了比较明显的异端思想和疑似女巫，天主教廷居然会组织法庭来进行审判，这实在是太不可思议了。在我们国家，如果皇帝想要杀掉他的某一个臣民，他只需要随便编一个借口即可，为什么要通过严格的法律程序进行审判呢？在中国，司法不过是一场表演。

然而直接的思想控制甚至还不是最主要的，在中国以擅长驯化人类知名的思想家商鞅就非常强调，与其控制人们的思想不如让其根本无法思考。（虽然在中国我们也知道《商君书》不全是商鞅一人的创作，书里面少不了商鞅的徒子徒孙和同道中人的“贡献”。不过在不影响理解的情况下，中国人一般会把《商君书》中的思想统一“归功”于商鞅，商鞅本人几乎成为一种文化符号。）事实上，中国统治者非常擅长这一点，在我国，所谓管理的最终目的，就是给被管理者带来无穷无尽的麻烦，迫使他们不断地犯“错误”进而制造出惩罚他们的理由。在这种环境下，无论是作为被统治阶级的农民还是作为统治

阶级的地主都难以进行维持生存以外的更加复杂的思考，前者不过是想要确保明天不被饿死，而后者不得不在官僚体制内钻营以保证自己仍能处于现有的地位。

毫不客气地讲，自从隋唐以来直至清朝末年被迫开国，我实在没有听说或者了解到中国有什么值得一提的思想家，实际上对于唐宋元明清的中国知识分子来说，没有一个人能够清楚地知道他们现在处于什么历史阶段，对于方向更是缺少判断，一直到了明末清初，满洲入关这样对汉人来说极为震撼的事件，才有个别人似乎意识到了一些端倪，然后在短短两代人的时间中又退回到程朱理学的堡垒里了。在官僚国家，人们既难以进行科学研究，又实实在在的没有任何动力去进行这一事业，因为在这里任何科学创造都无法转化成为可被保护的财富和荣誉，要想剥夺这些回报对于朝廷而言轻而易举，而后者又完全不需要付出什么代价。这种情况在今天不一样如此吗？人们重视官位而不重视学历，本质上还是因为官位能够在社会资源分配中起到决定性的作用，这就是商鞅当年想要达成的目标：利出一孔，而学位相比之下毫无价值。再加上官僚国家配备了科举制度这一强力武器，它就可以在不动用武力的情况下实现对于社会价值取向和思想的间接控制，确保一切可能造成改变的发明和发现都能流产。

如果我们总结以上三点，就会发现它完全以马克思和恩格斯物质决定意识，社会存在决定社会意识的基本观点的顺序列出。第一条是说官僚社会比起阶级社会人们既缺少余力又缺少意愿去扩大生产，改进技术，投资科学文化艺术领域，因而从生产力发展的角度来讲，官僚社会必然受到了极大的限制。第二条是说中国官僚社会比起阶级社会没有经历中世纪以来社会关系的有效重组，根本上来看缺乏进入现代社会的基本因素，这就是说其生产关系是极为落后和畸形的。第三条是说中国的官僚社会比起阶级社会在思想上更加禁锢和反动，人们的世界观，人生观和价值观以及所掌握的科学文化知识不要说有何种进步，其实很多证据证明最近一千多年在我国民众的认知水平甚至在退步（有关内容在后面补充），这就意味着从社会意识的角度来看这已经不是进步或者落后的问题了，我认为“退化”一词或许更为合适。

如此层层递进的枷锁完全扼杀了我国进入现代文明的可能性，毫不客气地讲，就拿清朝末年灾难性的生态恶化情况来看，如果不是洋人的坚船利炮打开了中国的国门，很难说这里不会变成一个大大的复活节岛，或者至少是一个大号的两河流域平原（核心文明无法确保自己的政治安全，总是反复地被边疆民族征服）。实际上，从中国帝制时代的后半段边疆少数民族频繁的入关来看，成为大号美索不达米亚已经不能说是一个可能而是一种现实了。

只有认真地了解中国的历史进程，人们才会强调这样一个不得不强调的事实，一阶级社会的确存在统治阶级对被统治阶级的残酷压迫，但是在往昔生产力根本不可能支持一个无阶级共产主义社会的时候，“让统治阶级进行统治”的确是历史的最优解。这当然不是说被统治阶级反抗统治阶级的斗争没有意义，无论是欧洲还是日本的历史都表明，底层人民的起义实实在在地推动了社会的进步，迫使统治阶级改良其统治，人类应有的历史进程就是这样由统治阶级和被统治阶级双方共同创造的。即使一个人认为这些理论分析难以辨明是非，他只需要实际看一看我国发生的历史就能够轻而易举地判断出对于占绝大多数人口的被统治阶级而言，与统治阶级打交道要远远好过在官僚社会中与统治阶级一起落入官僚体制这个大囚笼中。任何了解中国历史的人都绝对不可能不被我国波动起伏的历史人口曲线所震撼，当王朝更迭时，整个国家三分之一到三分之二的人口被集体消灭，单次消灭人口从汉末以来的千万级别到太平天国运动（及同期前后战乱）的可能上亿，如果放在欧洲一个国家的人口都不够死一次的。黑死病这样刻骨铭心的历史事件对西方人来说不过一次，但是对中国人来说十代之内必然见一次，战争、饥荒、瘟疫造成的规模惊人的非正常死亡事件，直到上个世纪后半叶也未停止。虽然不能排除有一定天灾的成分，但是如此密集和残酷的灾难仅在中国出现，怎么可能不是社会功能（这个功能不只是维持秩序的功能，也包括纠正和遏制暴政的功能）崩溃所造成的恶果呢？清末的中国百姓处于一种什么样的生存状态，到现在还有很多照片和历史文献作为证据，也不需要跟欧洲这样当时主宰世界的地区相对比，只需要跟邻国日本一对照，其是非成败已经自不待言了。

如果单就马克思和恩格斯来说，他们在当年犯的错误也并没有什么大不了，毕竟当一个人处于一个领域前沿没有任何可以追寻的对象时，犯错误也是十分平常的事情。如果说马克思和恩格斯一定有什么错误的话，大概就是太过自信地并且高估了当年的社会科学及哲学的发展水平认为其能够指导世界的运转甚至为自然科学领航，然而受过严格训练的科学家自然是不信这一点的。站在 21 世纪第三个十年开始的这个时间，我认为欧洲的所谓社会民主党所采取的路线是相对理智的，无论马克思和恩格斯这两位对他们来说的导师理论究竟成败几何，这些“对资产阶级投降的”社会主义党派至少在现实的实践中早晚能够分出真伪。真正将这种错误发展成为一种极端恶行的是以列宁为首俄国的布尔什维克党，这些野心

家充分利用了马克思和恩格斯忽视政府作为一个独立的阶层能够发挥巨大力量，而把社会存在的主要矛盾定性成为统治阶级和被统治阶级之间的对抗这一致命的错误，用马克思主义为自己的官僚极权统治背书。列宁具有创造性的一点在于，他把阶级交替过程中所产生的一般官僚政治进行了理论上的修饰，后来苏联及其影响下建立的一系列国家将其称为“先锋队”。于是在苏联以来的所谓共产主义国家的语境下，他们所建立的官僚政权已经不再是社会发展的自然结果，而是为了推翻旧社会必须建立起的战斗机器。但实际上他们既不愿意也不可能去摧毁一个旧社会，这些形形色色的宣传最终只是为官僚统治提供合法性，苏联共产党把党内拥有的惊人特权所掩盖掉，而把一切官僚统治造成的灾难都视为通往新社会必要的牺牲。最为重要的是，到了 20 世纪人类所拥有的科学技术已经与前代不可同日而语，这使得苏式国家的统治者可以明目张胆地树立一个假想敌，一开始是地主，后来是资本家，而不用像明清的官僚帝国一样至少在表面上还得承认士绅是国家的支柱，这是因为经过工业革命，政府所拥有的力量比以往变得更强大了。到目前为止，这显然是人类历史上所出现的最为恶劣，破坏性最大的政治体制以及最为危险的政治宣传，这与纳粹短短十二年的“千年帝国”完全没有可比性，希特勒所造成的破坏从长远来看绝对无法与苏联相提并论。